Lynceus: Accenture Hackathon Participant Brief

Spartan Hackathon · Nov 11, 2026 · @Mike Weston

The challenge

You have five hours to build a tool that lets an Accenture sales or delivery lead describe a client's problem in plain English and get back the past work that matches it, then prove your tool finds the right things.

We've called it Lynceus, after the lookout on the Argo who could see through walls, trees and solid ground and find whatever was buried there. He was also a Messenian who died fighting Castor and Pollux, the Spartan twins, so treat him well.

The brief comes from Accenture. They deliver work for clients in every industry and dozens of countries, and a lot of it could be reused: as a story to show a new client, or as tools, practices and expertise that keep the cost of the next delivery down. The hard part is finding it. One team's write-up uses its own industry's jargon, another's isn't in English, and nobody searching for 'call-centre backlog' thinks to look under 'citizen contact triage'.

Two examples from the material you'll be searching:

- A generative AI tool that rewrote more than 2,000 data-validation rules for the European Commission's fisheries department, each in about a minute.
- A cloud platform that uses satellite data, ground sensors and AI to find methane leaks in a US gas network in minutes instead of days.

A sales lead talking to a bank about rewriting thousands of legacy rules should find the first one, even though it's about fishing. One talking to a water company about leaks should find the second.

Two teams are working on this brief. Same material, same starting point, same five hours. The judges aren't looking for the slickest interface. They want a tool that surfaces the right work for real questions, explains why it chose each result, never claims anything the source doesn't say and admits when it hasn't found a good match.

What you're given

Each team gets an identical repository with everything below already loaded.

- **The corpus.** Write-ups of 30 past deliveries across 13 industries, from core banking to iron ore mining. Each is told one way only: in plain language, in the industry's own jargon or in another language, about a third of each, with nine languages besides

English. They're written as if by Veridane Partners, a fictional firm standing in for Accenture; the clients and the work are real and come from published stories. You get one plain text file per delivery, named only by a case number, with no title or labels. Working out what each one is about, and what language it's in, is your tool's job.

- **Sample questions.** Two questions in the style a sales or delivery lead would ask, with the deliveries each should find, so you can see the pattern. The questions you'll be judged on are held back.
- **A product owner.** Someone who knows how sales and delivery leads look for past work today, available all day to answer your questions. Use them.
- **Tooling.** The approved AI agent tooling installed on your machine, and an agent/skills folder with a skill template.
- **An empty evaluation folder.** For the test set you'll write before you build anything.

No one has built the tool for you, and there's no single right architecture. A well-organised keyword search with good enrichment can beat a vector database that nobody has tested. Choose what you can make work and prove in five hours.

What you'll deliver

Four deliverables, all committed to your team's repository by 14:45. Everything must run from a clean start with one command, without anyone editing the corpus by hand.

1. **A test set, written first.**
    - At least 10 questions a sales or delivery lead might ask, each with the entries you'd expect it to find. Write them before you build, with the product owner's help.
    - Include at least two questions that should match an entry written in another industry's vocabulary, one that should match an entry not in English and one where the right answer is that nothing fits.
2. **An enriched corpus.**
    - For every entry, a structured record your agent extracts: sector, country, the client problem in plain English, the capability or technique used, scale and outcome figures, language and what could be reused.
    - A person spot-checks at least 10 records against the source and corrects them. Keep the agent's draft and the corrected version side by side so the judges can see what changed.
3. **A working search tool.**
    - A lead types a need in plain English, such as 'a client wants to cut call-centre wait times with AI', and gets ranked results.
    - Each result shows a two-sentence summary, why it matched and a link to the source entry. Every claim in a summary must be traceable to the source text.

- When nothing is a strong match, the tool says so instead of padding the list.
- Any interface will do: command line, a simple web page or a chat. The interface isn't what's judged.

4. **Evaluation and evidence pack.**
   - Your tool run against your own test set, with the score (how often the right entry appears in the top three) and every miss explained.
   - One page in the repository covering how it works, what you chose not to do and why, the known limitations and what it would take to put it in front of Accenture's sales teams.
   - An agent log: which skill ran, which model, the prompt, what it produced and what a person changed.

Your team and roles

Your team is drawn from different cohorts, so some of you will have built search or data pipelines before and some won't. Agree roles in the first 20 minutes. A smaller team doubles up; a larger one pairs people on the busiest roles.

Role	Owns
Delivery lead	The plan, priorities, keeping time and pulling the streams together
Business analyst	How leads search today, questions for the product owner, the test set
Data engineer	Loading and cleaning the corpus, handling missing fields and other languages
Search engineer	Matching and ranking, and explaining why each result was chosen
Agent engineer	The enrichment skills, running the agent and keeping the agent log
Evaluation lead	Running the test set, scoring it and explaining every miss
Evidence and demo lead	The evidence pack and the demo script

Everyone speaks in the demo. The judges score how you worked together as well as what you built.

How the day runs

The challenge runs from 09:30 to 14:45. Code freezes at 14:45, and the last commit before then is what gets judged.

Time	What happens
09:30 to 09:50	Kick-off. Read this brief, agree roles and confirm the repository and tooling work on every laptop
09:50 to 10:30	Explore and plan. Read a sample of the corpus, question the product owner on how leads search today, write your test set and agree your approach
10:30 to 12:30	Build. Work in parallel on loading, enrichment, search and evaluation; start the evidence pack. Lunch is a working lunch
12:30 to 13:15	Live round (see below)
13:15 to 13:45	Stretch: the client-ready note
13:45 to 14:25	Finish the evaluation and evidence pack
14:25 to 14:45	Run everything from a clean start, push to main
From 14:45	Code freeze. Prepare and rehearse your presentation

Presentations to the client and judges follow in the afternoon.

The live round

At 12:30 a facilitator gives both teams the same two things at the same time:

- **New entries.** Nine more deliveries your tool hasn't seen: four in industry jargon and five in languages that aren't in the original corpus.
- **Held-back questions.** Five questions, three of them written by Accenture's sales and delivery leads, with answers only the judges hold.

Load the new entries through your normal pipeline, then run the questions. For each question, your evidence pack and demo should show:

- what your tool returned and why it ranked things that way
- whether you think it got the right answer, and how you checked
- for a miss, what went wrong: the enrichment, the matching, the question or the corpus

- whether the new entries came through without anyone touching them by hand

Tuning your tool to the five questions loses marks. If a question exposes a weakness, log it and say how you'd fix it properly.

Stretch: the client-ready note

At 13:15 the product owner gives you a new request.

> A sales lead is meeting a new client tomorrow. Given the client's problem in a sentence, produce a one-page note the lead can take into the room: two or three relevant pieces of past work, what was done, the results and what could be reused.

Using your agent and your own judgement:

1. Ask the product owner what a sales lead can and can't say to a client about past work.
2. Generate the note from your tool's results for one held-back question.
3. Trace every claim in the note to a line in the source entry.
4. Flag anything that shouldn't go in front of a client, such as a client name or figure the source marks as confidential.
5. Show what the agent drafted and what a person changed.

Ground rules

- **The corpus stays in the room.** It lives in your team's repository on Sparta Global machines and is deleted after the event. Don't copy it anywhere else or discuss client details outside the hackathon.
- **Use only the agent tooling provided.** Don't paste the corpus into any other AI service.
- **No invented claims.** If a summary says something the source doesn't, it's wrong, however plausible it sounds.
- **Don't edit the corpus to make a search work.** Fix your pipeline instead, and log the problem you found in the data.
- **No unreviewed agent output.** Every enrichment record or summary the judges see has had a person's review, recorded in the agent log.
- **Commit little and often** to your team's repository.

How you'll be judged

The panel is the client, a Sparta Global commercial lead and a faculty specialist.

Criterion	Weight	What good looks like
Finds the right work	25%	The right entries in the top three for the held-back questions
Trustworthy answers	20%	Every result explained, every claim traced to its source, no padding when nothing fits
Across jargon and languages	15%	Matches that cross industry vocabulary and language, new entries handled without rework
Agent skills and human control	15%	Well-defined enrichment skills, an honest agent log, people correcting the agent's work
Evaluation and honesty	15%	A test set written before building, a real score, every miss explained
Teamwork and evidence	10%	Clear roles, a joined-up evidence pack, the whole team in the demo

Your demo

You have seven minutes, then three minutes of questions from the panel. Suggested running order:

1. Start from clean and load the corpus.
2. Ask a sales lead's question live and walk through the results and why each was chosen.
3. Show a match across industry jargon and one across languages.
4. Show an enrichment record as the agent drafted it and as your team corrected it.
5. Give your evaluation score and explain a miss you understand.
6. Walk through the live round: what your tool found, what it missed and why.
7. Close with what it would take to put this in front of Accenture's sales and delivery teams.

Every member of the team presents part of it.